

FactCheckBD

An AI-Based Fact-Verification Tool for Bangladesh — Project Brief

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The Problem

Bangladesh is experiencing a measurable shift from traditional rumor-based misinformation to industrial-scale, AI-driven deception, particularly during politically sensitive periods. A January–April 2026 quantitative analysis of 2,402 verified misinformation cases (cross-referenced with Rumor Scanner, Dismislab, and Fact-Watch) found that 416 cases were purely AI-generated — including voice cloning, deepfake visuals, and synthetic narrative generation. Political content peaked at 87% of all flagged cases in February 2026, and the digital identities of over 6 major news outlets were impersonated to lend false legitimacy to fabricated reports. This represents a structural attack on the infrastructure of informed citizenship — one that manual fact-checking alone cannot scale to meet.

Approach

FactCheckBD is a lightweight, bilingual (Bengali/English) AI claim-screening tool designed as a first line of defense for readers, journalists, and civic organizations. Users paste a claim, headline, or viral message and receive a structured preliminary assessment — a plausibility verdict, confidence score, explanation, identified red flags (e.g. fake-giveaway patterns, fabricated quotes, manipulated health claims, recycled hoaxes), and concrete next steps for verification. The tool is explicitly positioned as a triage and literacy aid that directs users toward established fact-checking organizations, not a replacement for them.

Current Prototype

- Working bilingual (Bengali/English) Gradio web app, publicly deployed and live.
- LLM-based reasoning engine (Qwen 2.5-7B-Instruct) returns structured, machine-readable verdicts — verdict, confidence, explanation, red flags, and verification tips.
- Dark, accessible UI with built-in example claims drawn from common Bangladeshi misinformation patterns.
- Open methodology and limitations documented in-app for transparency.

Impact Potential

- Gives ordinary citizens an accessible, instant first check before sharing a claim — reducing the velocity of viral misinformation.
- Supports newsroom and civic-tech workflows by pre-screening high volumes of user-submitted tips, freeing human fact-checkers to focus on high-risk cases.
- Directly addresses the AI-generated misinformation segment (~17% of verified cases in early 2026 and rising) that current manual pipelines are not built to triage at scale.
- Bilingual design lowers the access barrier for Bengali-speaking users, who are underserved by existing English-first fact-checking tools.

Roadmap

- **Phase 1 (current):** Public demo with LLM-based reasoning, no live web access.
- **Phase 2:** Integrate live news/web retrieval and a structured claim database to cross-check against verified fact-checks from partner organizations.
- **Phase 3:** Fine-tune a Bengali-specialized verification model on labeled Bangladeshi misinformation datasets to improve accuracy on local context, dialects, and recurring hoax formats.
- **Phase 4:** Build integrations (API/widget) for newsroom tip lines and civic-tech platforms, plus a public dashboard tracking misinformation trends.

Background research: Rafi, N.A. (2026). *The 2026 Electoral Information Crisis: A Quantitative Analysis*. Report No. IB-NR-2026-04-EN. DOI: 10.13140/RG.2.2.21746.67526.

This is a research prototype. It is intended to support — not replace — established fact-checking organizations.